Chapter 8 · Story

“Anyone can join.” The form says otherwise.

An original story at the Common Ground repair café.



The invisible doorway · c08s01

A fictional story. A real question about people.

What would you do?

How should the team investigate unequal access?

A Ask whether organizers consider themselves fair.

B Trace who can enter each stage and where people drop out.

C Add a fairness slogan to the poster.

Suggested answer: B. Tracing each stage can reveal access barriers that intentions and slogans miss.

Separate belief, attitude, and action.

- **Stereotype**: a generalized group belief.
- **Prejudice**: an attitude toward a group, often involving dislike.
- **Discrimination**: unequal treatment based on group membership.
- Evidence about one does not establish everything about the others.

Three related, distinct concepts

Stereotype: a group belief

“Every newcomer lacks repair skills.”

Prejudice: an attitude

“I dislike newcomers before meeting them.”

Discrimination: unequal treatment

Reject someone for being a newcomer.

These need not form an inevitable sequence.

Belief, attitude, and action are related but distinct.

Follow the route into participation.

- **Recruitment**: who never hears about the opportunity?
- **Requirements**: who lacks the tools or resources to enter?
- **Timing**: who cannot attend during working hours?
- **Evidence**: examine access and outcomes, not intentions alone.

A welcoming intention can leave barriers

1. **Recruit through existing friends**
   Who never hears about the opportunity?
2. **Require personally owned tools**
   Who lacks the resources to enter?
3. **Meet during working hours**
   Who cannot attend?
4. **Inspect the process and outcomes**
   Intentions alone cannot establish fairness

Rules can favor an existing group.

An arrangement can exclude without an openly hostile statement.

Contact needs meaningful participation.

- **Intergroup contact**: interaction between members of different groups.
- Support cooperation, shared goals, equal status, and organizer backing.
- Sharing a room is not the same as sharing decisions.
- Check whether newcomers can actually participate.

Sharing a room and sharing participation

Limited participation



Newcomers watch. Established members control the tools and decisions.

Cooperative contact



Work on a shared goal. Share relevant tools and decision-making. Organizers support equal participation.

Intergroup contact can help under some conditions. Check actual access and participation.

Cooperation, equal status, shared goals, and support matter.

Change the rule that creates the barrier.

- **Procedural change**: remove an unnecessary entry requirement.
- **Example**: open applications beyond existing friends.
- **Example**: share specialist tools where feasible.
- Evaluate access, progression, and participation; protect privacy.

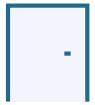
Change the barrier in the process

Existing rule



Apply through existing friends.
Bring your own specialist tools.

A proposed change



Open the application.
Use relevant criteria.
Provide shared tools where feasible.
Track participation.

A friendly encounter alone leaves the rule intact.
Use follow-up and protect privacy.

Examine who can enter and participate after the change.

What can we really conclude?

An explicit attitude is an evaluation someone reports directly. An implicit association is a link between ideas that may be measured indirectly, such as through the speed of responses in a sorting task. Discriminatory behavior concerns how people are actually treated. When interpreting a participant's implicit-association score, remember that it is not a complete diagnosis of that person's character or a forecast of every action. When evaluating a recruitment change, inspect access and participation: who can apply, progress, and remain involved? Include follow-up and the experiences of applicants. An organizer saying "I am fair" cannot establish that those outcomes are fair. Interpret small samples cautiously and protect privacy. Investigating unequal access does not justify collecting unnecessary personal information.

Different measures answer different questions

Explicit attitude

What someone reports directly

Implicit association

An indirect response pattern in a task

Behavior and access

Who can apply, progress, and participate?

No single score is a complete character diagnosis.

Different measurements do not supply a complete character diagnosis.

Try the idea somewhere new.

Friend referrals become an open skills-based application. How can improvement be assessed?

A Check whether organizers feel more inclusive.

B Compare the friendliness of form wording.

C Track applications, progression, and participation using relevant criteria.

Suggested answer: C. Applications, progression, and participation can show where barriers remain. Interpret those outcomes with context and privacy safeguards.

Close your notes. Explain it.

> Give an example of discrimination without an openly hostile statement.

> Why might a contact event leave unequal access unchanged?

1. An irrelevant requirement or restricted network can exclude a group without an openly hostile statement.

2. Contact can leave unequal access unchanged when decision power, incentives, status differences, or procedures remain the same.



Maya, Sam and Leo at the repair café.

Carry one idea into your week.

Review a process you are authorized to examine. Identify an unnecessary barrier, propose a change, and select a fair outcome measure without collecting unnecessary personal data.

Revisit tomorrow and in a week.
Explain it without notes, then use a different example.



Take the question into a different setting.